

OCCUPATIONAL THERAPY ACTIVITIES FOR KIDS

Fine Motor & Sensory Workbook

Home Activities to Build Skills

By Daniel Tesfamariam

Copyright 2025 Daniel Tesfamariam. All rights reserved.

Consult with your child's OT for personalized recommendations.

PENCIL GRIP GUIDE

Proper pencil grip develops over time. Don't rush!

DEVELOPMENTAL PROGRESSION:

1. FIST GRIP (ages 1-2): Whole hand wraps around crayon
2. DIGITAL PRONATE (ages 2-3): Fingers point down, wrist moves
3. MODIFIED TRIPOD (ages 3-4): Thumb + 2 fingers, some wrist movement
4. DYNAMIC TRIPOD (ages 4-6): Thumb + index + middle, fingers move

THE IDEAL TRIPOD GRIP:

- Pencil rests on middle finger
- Thumb and index finger pinch gently
- Ring and pinky fingers curl into palm for stability
- Wrist is slightly extended (not bent)

ACTIVITIES TO BUILD GRIP STRENGTH:

- Tear paper into small pieces (builds pinch strength)
- Squeeze play dough / theraputty
- Pick up small objects with tweezers
- Lacing and threading beads
- Opening and closing clothespins
- Spinning tops between thumb and fingers
- Drawing on a vertical surface (builds wrist position)

PENCIL GRIPS TO TRY (if needed):

- Triangular grip
- Crossover grip
- The Pencil Grip brand

CUTTING SKILLS PROGRESSION

Scissor skills develop in a specific order:

LEVEL 1: SNIPPING (ages 2-3)

- Open/close scissors (snip play dough first!)
- Single snips across paper strips
- Cut fringe along edge of paper

LEVEL 2: STRAIGHT LINES (ages 3-4)

- Cut along wide straight lines (start with 1-inch paths)
- Cut across a full sheet of paper
- Cut between two parallel lines

LEVEL 3: CURVED LINES (ages 4-5)

- Cut gentle curves
- Cut wavy lines
- Cut along zigzag lines

LEVEL 4: SHAPES (ages 5-6)

- Cut out circles (hardest shape!)
- Cut out squares and triangles
- Cut out complex shapes

TIPS FOR SUCCESS:

- Thumb goes on top, fingers on bottom
- 'Thumbs up!' position
- Stabilizing hand holds and turns the paper
- Use spring-loaded scissors for beginners
- Practice with play dough before paper

TRACING PATHS - EASY

Trace along the dotted paths from START to END:

START - - - - - END

START - - - - - END

START - - - - - END

START - - - - - END

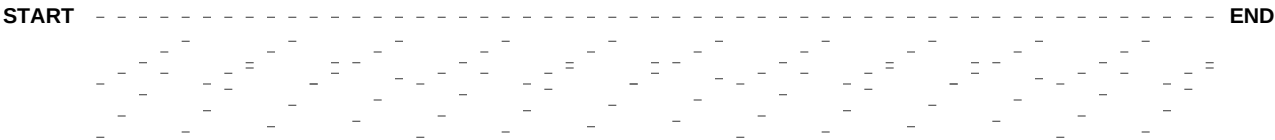
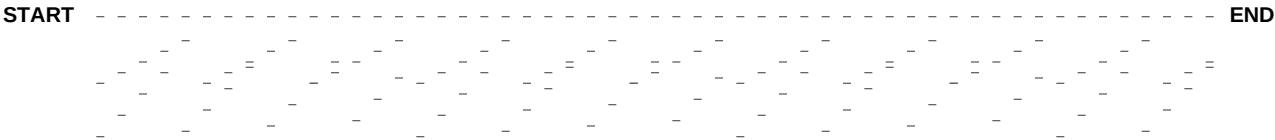
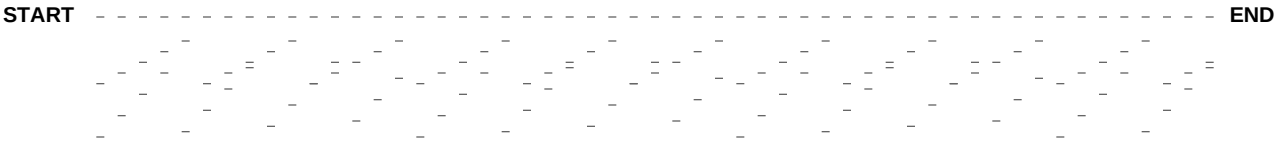
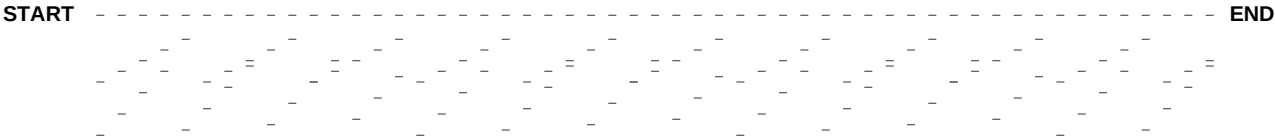
TRACING PATHS - MEDIUM

Trace along the dotted paths from START to END:



TRACING PATHS - HARD

Trace along the dotted paths from START to END:



BEAD PATTERN COPYING

Copy the pattern on the left to the empty spaces on the right:

Pattern 1:

0 0 X 0 0 X

— — — — — — —

Pattern 2:

X 0 0 X 0 0

— — — — — — —

Pattern 3:

0 X 0 X 0 X

— — — — — — —

Pattern 4:

X X 0 0 X X

— — — — — — —

Pattern 5:

0 X X 0 X X

— — — — — — —

FINGER STRENGTHENING EXERCISES

Strong fingers = better handwriting, cutting, and self-care!

PUTTY/PLAY DOUGH EXERCISES:

1. Roll into a snake (palms together, forward/back)
2. Pinch off small pieces (thumb + each finger)
3. Poke holes with each finger individually
4. Hide small beads inside, then find them
5. Flatten with palm, then roll back into ball

CLOTHESPIN ACTIVITIES:

1. Clip clothespins around a paper plate edge
2. Pick up cotton balls with clothespin 'tweezers'
3. Clip matching colors to color cards
4. Build a tower of clothespins

EVERYDAY ACTIVITIES THAT BUILD STRENGTH:

- Opening containers and jars (with help)
- Squeezing sponges in the bath
- Pulling apart building blocks (Lego, Duplo)
- Spray bottles (watering plants!)
- Hole punch (great for pinch strength!)
- Tearing lettuce for salad
- Peeling stickers off a sheet
- Buttoning and zipping own clothes

DAILY PRACTICE: Choose 2-3 activities, 5-10 minutes each.

SENSORY DIET BUILDER

A 'sensory diet' is a planned schedule of sensory activities to help your child stay regulated throughout the day.

ALERTING ACTIVITIES (wakes up the brain):

- ☐ Jumping on trampoline ☐ Cold water on hands
- ☐ Crunchy foods ☐ Bright lights
- ☐ Fast music ☐ Spinning (briefly)

CALMING ACTIVITIES (settles the brain):

- ☐ Deep pressure (bear hugs, weighted blanket)
- ☐ Slow rocking ☐ Warm bath
- ☐ Quiet music ☐ Dim lighting
- ☐ Chewy foods/gum ☐ Proprioception (heavy work)

HEAVY WORK (proprioceptive input - universally calming):

- ☐ Carrying groceries ☐ Pushing laundry basket
- ☐ Climbing ☐ Wheelbarrow walks
- ☐ Animal walks ☐ Pulling wagon
- ☐ Wall push-ups ☐ Digging in sand

MY CHILD'S SENSORY SCHEDULE:

Morning: _____

Before school: _____

After school: _____

Before homework: _____

Before bed: _____

SELF-REGULATION ZONES

Help your child identify and manage their energy levels:

HIGH ZONE (too much energy/too fast):

Feels like: silly, wild, angry, scared, out of control

Tools to come DOWN: deep breaths, heavy work, quiet space,
bear hug, weighted lap pad, drink water through straw

JUST RIGHT ZONE (ready to learn and play):

Feels like: calm, focused, happy, ready

This is where we want to be for learning!

LOW ZONE (too little energy/too slow):

Feels like: tired, bored, sad, sick, zoned out

Tools to come UP: movement break, crunchy snack, cold water,
jumping jacks, music, bright light, fidget tool

MY CHILD'S SIGNS FOR EACH ZONE:

HIGH: _____

JUST RIGHT: _____

LOW: _____

TOOLS THAT WORK FOR MY CHILD:

To calm down: _____

To wake up: _____

DAILY OT HOME PROGRAM - WEEK 1

Monday:

Fine motor activity: _____
Gross motor/sensory: _____
Self-care practice: ____ Duration: ____ Mood: ____

Tuesday:

Fine motor activity: _____
Gross motor/sensory: _____
Self-care practice: ____ Duration: ____ Mood: ____

Wednesday:

Fine motor activity: _____
Gross motor/sensory: _____
Self-care practice: ____ Duration: ____ Mood: ____

Thursday:

Fine motor activity: _____
Gross motor/sensory: _____
Self-care practice: ____ Duration: ____ Mood: ____

Friday:

Fine motor activity: _____
Gross motor/sensory: _____
Self-care practice: ____ Duration: ____ Mood: ____

Saturday:

Fine motor activity: _____
Gross motor/sensory: _____
Self-care practice: ____ Duration: ____ Mood: ____

Sunday:

Fine motor activity: _____
Gross motor/sensory: _____
Self-care practice: ____ Duration: ____ Mood: ____

DAILY OT HOME PROGRAM - WEEK 2

Monday:

Fine motor activity: _____
Gross motor/sensory: _____
Self-care practice: ____ Duration: ____ Mood: ____

Tuesday:

Fine motor activity: _____
Gross motor/sensory: _____
Self-care practice: ____ Duration: ____ Mood: ____

Wednesday:

Fine motor activity: _____
Gross motor/sensory: _____
Self-care practice: ____ Duration: ____ Mood: ____

Thursday:

Fine motor activity: _____
Gross motor/sensory: _____
Self-care practice: ____ Duration: ____ Mood: ____

Friday:

Fine motor activity: _____
Gross motor/sensory: _____
Self-care practice: ____ Duration: ____ Mood: ____

Saturday:

Fine motor activity: _____
Gross motor/sensory: _____
Self-care practice: ____ Duration: ____ Mood: ____

Sunday:

Fine motor activity: _____
Gross motor/sensory: _____
Self-care practice: ____ Duration: ____ Mood: ____

DAILY OT HOME PROGRAM - WEEK 3

Monday:

Fine motor activity: _____
Gross motor/sensory: _____
Self-care practice: ____ Duration: ____ Mood: ____

Tuesday:

Fine motor activity: _____
Gross motor/sensory: _____
Self-care practice: ____ Duration: ____ Mood: ____

Wednesday:

Fine motor activity: _____
Gross motor/sensory: _____
Self-care practice: ____ Duration: ____ Mood: ____

Thursday:

Fine motor activity: _____
Gross motor/sensory: _____
Self-care practice: ____ Duration: ____ Mood: ____

Friday:

Fine motor activity: _____
Gross motor/sensory: _____
Self-care practice: ____ Duration: ____ Mood: ____

Saturday:

Fine motor activity: _____
Gross motor/sensory: _____
Self-care practice: ____ Duration: ____ Mood: ____

Sunday:

Fine motor activity: _____
Gross motor/sensory: _____
Self-care practice: ____ Duration: ____ Mood: ____

DAILY OT HOME PROGRAM - WEEK 4

Monday:

Fine motor activity: _____
Gross motor/sensory: _____
Self-care practice: ____ Duration: ____ Mood: ____

Tuesday:

Fine motor activity: _____
Gross motor/sensory: _____
Self-care practice: ____ Duration: ____ Mood: ____

Wednesday:

Fine motor activity: _____
Gross motor/sensory: _____
Self-care practice: ____ Duration: ____ Mood: ____

Thursday:

Fine motor activity: _____
Gross motor/sensory: _____
Self-care practice: ____ Duration: ____ Mood: ____

Friday:

Fine motor activity: _____
Gross motor/sensory: _____
Self-care practice: ____ Duration: ____ Mood: ____

Saturday:

Fine motor activity: _____
Gross motor/sensory: _____
Self-care practice: ____ Duration: ____ Mood: ____

Sunday:

Fine motor activity: _____
Gross motor/sensory: _____
Self-care practice: ____ Duration: ____ Mood: ____

DAILY OT HOME PROGRAM - WEEK 5

Monday:

Fine motor activity: _____
Gross motor/sensory: _____
Self-care practice: ____ Duration: ____ Mood: ____

Tuesday:

Fine motor activity: _____
Gross motor/sensory: _____
Self-care practice: ____ Duration: ____ Mood: ____

Wednesday:

Fine motor activity: _____
Gross motor/sensory: _____
Self-care practice: ____ Duration: ____ Mood: ____

Thursday:

Fine motor activity: _____
Gross motor/sensory: _____
Self-care practice: ____ Duration: ____ Mood: ____

Friday:

Fine motor activity: _____
Gross motor/sensory: _____
Self-care practice: ____ Duration: ____ Mood: ____

Saturday:

Fine motor activity: _____
Gross motor/sensory: _____
Self-care practice: ____ Duration: ____ Mood: ____

Sunday:

Fine motor activity: _____
Gross motor/sensory: _____
Self-care practice: ____ Duration: ____ Mood: ____

PROGRESS TRACKING & OT GOALS

Track your child's OT progress:

GOAL 1: _____

Start date: _____ Baseline: _____

Week 2: _____ Week 4: _____

Week 6: _____ Week 8: _____

GOAL 2: _____

Start date: _____ Baseline: _____

Week 2: _____ Week 4: _____

Week 6: _____ Week 8: _____

GOAL 3: _____

Start date: _____ Baseline: _____

Week 2: _____ Week 4: _____

Week 6: _____ Week 8: _____

SKILLS MASTERED (celebrate!):

— _____ Date: _____

— _____ Date: _____

— _____ Date: _____

— _____ Date: _____

— _____ Date: _____